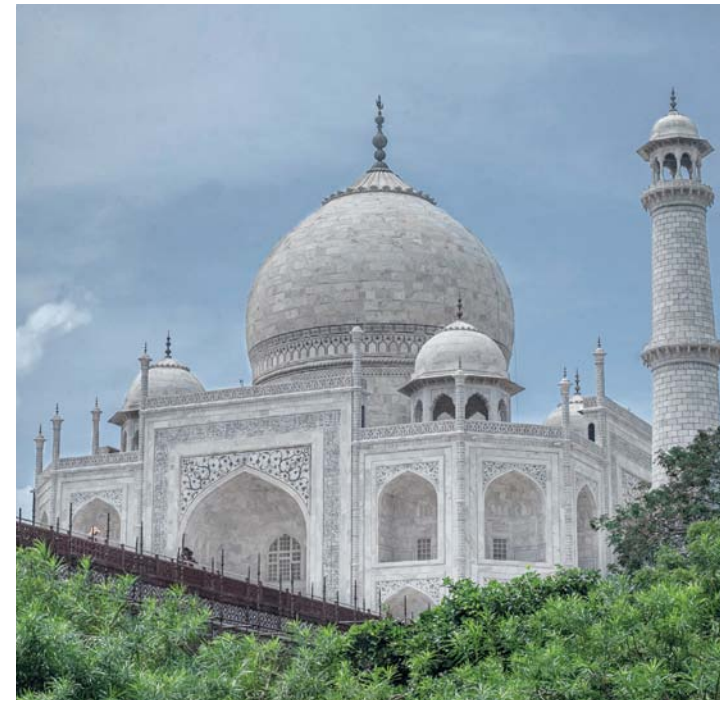
(In May 1666, the peasant army of Gokula Jat faced the Mughal army in the Battle of Tilpat.)

The most controversial, of course, is the campaign to rename the Taj. On August 31, Shobha Ram Rathore, the BJP councillor in the Agra Municipal Corporation, proposed that the marble mausoleum be renamed Tejo Mahalaya. "There are many reasons for it," he says. "The monument was named so by a foreign traveller. The present name is a distortion of Tejo Mahalaya. The word 'Mahal' is not associated with any cemetery in the world." However, the motion could not be discussed due to a clash between the BJP and Bahujan Samaj Party councillors in the House. "The proposal will be considered for discussion in the next sitting of the House," says mayor Naveen Jain, though he admits that renaming the Taj Mahal is outside the jurisdiction of the corporation. Rathore is intent on pushing his proposal again.

"The BJP government," says Ramji Lal Suman, former national general secretary of the Samajwadi Party (SP), "is targeting the Mughal-era monuments. The government has not done any development work here in the past five years. It has only changed the names of roads, parks and monuments." For a city that was once the capital of the Mughal empire, and is home to three Unesco World Heritage Sites—the Taj Mahal (which alone draws around eight million visitors annually), the Agra Fort and the Fatehpur Sikri—the renaming spree is nothing but an undisguised attempt to rewrite history. "Instead of giving priority to the works of public interest," says Shiromani Singh, the only Congress councillor in the corporation, "the corporation has changed the identity of more than 50 roads and crossings in Agra in the past five years by renaming them, but the situation has still not changed."

And nothing symbolises it better than the fate of the Mughal Museum-turned-Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Museum. It was the Akhilesh Yadav-led SP government that had started the construction of the state-of-the-art project—also touted as the state's biggest—in January 2016 on Power House land. The deadline for the Rs 141-crore project was December 2017. Construction work picked up pace in the first year when the main structure was built with Rs 99 crore. But then just a year later, the leadership in Uttar Pradesh changed, with the Yogi Adityanath-led BJP government taking charge in March 2017.

Later, a denial of funds led to construction coming to a standstill. In September 2020, the government renamed the museum in honour of Chhatrapati Shivaji. However, as an engineer involved in the construction, says, "The name was changed, but the budget for its construction was not released. Because of this, the builder, Tata Projects, quit the work. However, during this period, the cost has escalated to Rs 186 crore." Deepak Dan, president of the Tourist Guide Welfare Association in Agra, says that they



WHAT'S IN A RENAME?

1. Naubasta crossing, Lohamandi >> **Guru Nanak Dev Chowk**
2. Kangalpada area, Mantola >> **Veerangana Jhalkari Bai Muhallah**
3. The road from Kidwai Park to the old post office >> **Veer Tantya Tope Marg**
4. Power House Crossing >> **Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Crossing**
5. Rambagh-Nunihai link road >> **Karpoori Thakur Road**
6. The road from Chhipitola to Sanchi Gate >> **Bhagat Singh Road**
7. Chhipitola intersection >> **Lord Mahavir Swami Chowk**
8. Ghatiya Azam Khan Road >> **Ashok Singhal Marg**
9. The road from New Agra to Poonam Plaza >> **Sant Gadge Maharaj Marg**
10. Nalband crossing >> **Maharaja Daksha Prajapati Chowk**
11. The crossing in front of Shahjahan Garden >> **Gokula Chowk**
12. Mughal Road, Kamla Nagar >> **Maharaja Agrasen Road**

